



EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATION TOOLKIT

Copy-paste templates for every situation. Master the art of executive communication with proven frameworks that get results.



THE DECISION REQUEST EMAIL

SUBJECT LINE FORMULA

Decision Needed: [Topic] by [Deadline]

This format immediately signals urgency and clarity. Your executive knows exactly what's required before opening the email. The deadline creates accountability and enables proper prioritization within their packed schedule.

THE SITUATION

Open with 2-3 sentences that provide essential context. Why does this decision matter now? What's the business impact? Connect the request to strategic priorities your executive cares about. Avoid backstory—focus on what they need to know to decide.



THE OPTIONS

Option A: Present the first path forward with clear pros and cons

Option B: Present the alternative with equal clarity

Keep each option to 2-3 bullet points maximum

YOUR RECOMMENDATION

I recommend [X] because [reason].

Take a clear stance. Executives value team members who analyze options and make recommendations rather than just presenting choices.

THE CLOSE

Can you confirm by [deadline]?

End with a specific, actionable request. Make it easy for them to respond with a simple yes/no or quick feedback.

THE EXECUTIVE UPDATE EMAIL

1

STATUS AT A GLANCE

Subject: [Project] Update - [Status]

Use visual indicators that enable instant comprehension:  On Track when everything is proceeding as planned,  At Risk when there are concerns but mitigation is underway,  Off Track when immediate intervention is required.

2

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

Lead with wins. Highlight 2-3 significant achievements from the reporting period. Use metrics wherever possible—executives think in numbers. Frame accomplishments in terms of business impact, not just task completion.

3

UPCOMING MILESTONES

Provide clear visibility into the next 2-4 weeks. Format as bullet points with specific dates. This demonstrates you're thinking ahead and enables your executive to allocate resources or make decisions proactively.

4

BLOCKERS & SOLUTIONS

Never present a problem without a proposed solution. Describe the issue concisely, then immediately follow with your recommended path forward. This shows ownership and strategic thinking.

5

SUPPORT NEEDED

Be specific about what you need. Rather than "need more resources," say "need approval to hire two engineers by end of Q2" or "need 30 minutes with CFO to align on budget."

THE ONE-PAGE MEMO

The one-page memo is the gold standard for executive communication. It forces clarity, demonstrates respect for time, and ensures your key message doesn't get lost in details. Amazon famously banned PowerPoint in favor of six-page narrative memos. Start with the one-page version.

01

HEADER BLOCK

TO: [Name] | FROM: [Your Name] | DATE: [Date] | RE: [Subject]

02

RECOMMENDATION FIRST

State your recommendation in one clear sentence. Busy executives may only read this line. Make it count.

03

CONTEXT SECTION

Provide 2-3 sentences explaining why this matters now. Connect to business objectives and strategic priorities.

04

ANALYSIS

Present 3 key points that support your recommendation. Use data, examples, and logical reasoning.

05

NEXT STEPS

List specific actions with owners and deadlines. Format: [Action] - [Owner] - [Deadline]



THE MEETING REQUEST

Meetings are expensive. A 60-minute meeting with five executives can cost thousands of dollars in opportunity cost. Respect that investment by making your request crystal clear and well-structured. The best meeting requests get accepted because they demonstrate the value of the time investment upfront.



SUBJECT LINE

Request: [Duration] Meeting on [Topic]

Specify the time commitment upfront. "Request: 30 Minutes on Q3 Budget" is better than "Let's Talk About Budget."



PURPOSE STATEMENT

One sentence explaining why this meeting matters. Connect to outcomes they care about: revenue, risk, strategy, or team development.



STRUCTURED AGENDA

Break the meeting into timed segments. Show you've thought through the flow and will use their time efficiently.



EASY SCHEDULING

Offer 2-3 specific time options. Make it easy to say yes with minimal back-and-forth.

Pro Tip: Include any required prep work. "Please review the attached 2-page brief" or "No prep needed—I'll present options live." This helps them plan and shows respect for their time.

THE MEETING RECAP



Send meeting recaps within 24 hours while details are fresh. This isn't just good practice—it's a strategic tool. Recaps create accountability, prevent misalignment, and serve as documentation if questions arise later. They also demonstrate your organizational skills and follow-through.

The format should be scannable. Use clear headers and bullet points. Avoid narrative paragraphs that bury key information. Anyone who wasn't in the meeting should be able to understand what happened and what needs to happen next.



DECISIONS MADE

List each decision in clear, declarative language. "We will launch in Q3" not "We discussed launching in Q3." Decisions are commitments, not possibilities.



ACTION ITEMS

Format: [Action] - [Owner] - [Deadline]. Every action item needs a name and a date. "Team will research options" is not actionable. "Sarah will present three vendor options by March 15" is.



NEXT MEETING

If there's a follow-up, confirm the date and time. If not needed, say so explicitly: "No follow-up meeting required unless issues arise."

ASKING FOR A RAISE

Asking for a raise is a business negotiation, not a personal favor. The most successful salary conversations are rooted in data, delivered with confidence, and framed around mutual value. You're not asking for money because you need it—you're requesting fair compensation for measurable contributions.



OPENING STATEMENT

"I'd like to discuss my compensation." Direct and professional. Don't apologize or hedge. This is a legitimate business conversation.



EVIDENCE OF IMPACT

"Over the past [period], I've delivered [result 1], [result 2], and [result 3], which have had measurable impact on [business outcome]." Use specific metrics and connect your work to company goals.



MARKET CONTEXT

"Based on my contributions and market rate..." Research compensation data for your role, level, and geography. Sites like Levels.fyi, Glassdoor, and Payscale provide benchmarks.



SPECIFIC REQUEST

"I'd like to request a [X%] increase to \$[amount]." Be specific. Ranges make you look uncertain. A precise number signals you've done your homework.



FUTURE COMMITMENT

"I'm committed to continuing to drive results. What are your thoughts?" End by reaffirming your value and opening dialogue.

- ☐ **Timing Matters:** The best time to ask is after a significant win, during performance review cycles, or when you've taken on substantially more responsibility. Avoid asking during budget freezes or organizational upheaval.



DECLINING POLITELY

Saying no is a critical skill. You can't say yes to everything without compromising your core responsibilities and performance. The best declines are respectful, brief, and offer alternatives when possible. They preserve relationships while protecting your time and energy.

The key is to decline the request, not the person. Express appreciation for being considered, provide a concise reason, and when appropriate, suggest other ways to help. This approach maintains goodwill and demonstrates that you're a team player with appropriate boundaries.



1

EXPRESS APPRECIATION

"Thanks for thinking of me for [request]." Start positive. Acknowledge that being asked is a compliment to your expertise or capabilities.

2

CLEAR DECLINE

"Unfortunately, I won't be able to [do X] because [brief reason]." Be direct but kind. You don't need to over-explain, but a brief reason helps them understand.

3

OFFER ALTERNATIVES

"However, I'd like to suggest [alternative]." Provide 1-2 options: recommend someone else, offer a different form of support, or suggest a future timeline.

4

GRACIOUS CLOSE

"Let me know if there's another way I can support." Keep the door open for future collaboration while maintaining your boundary on this request.

GIVING DIFFICULT FEEDBACK

Difficult feedback is one of the most valuable gifts you can give a team member, yet it's also one of the most challenging conversations to navigate. The goal isn't to make someone feel bad—it's to help them improve and succeed. When delivered well, difficult feedback strengthens relationships and performance. When delivered poorly, it damages both.

1

NAME THE BEHAVIOR

"I want to talk about [specific behavior]." Be direct and specific. Don't talk about personality or attitude—focus on observable actions.

2

PROVIDE EXAMPLES

"I've noticed [example 1] and [example 2]." Give concrete instances. Vague feedback can't be acted on. Specific examples make the issue real and undeniable.

3

EXPLAIN IMPACT

"This is impacting [team/results] in these ways: [impact 1] and [impact 2]." Help them understand why this matters. Connect behavior to consequences.

4

EXPRESS CONFIDENCE

"I believe you're capable of [desired behavior]." This is crucial. Show you're invested in their success and believe they can change.

5

SET CLEAR EXPECTATIONS

"Here's what I'd like to see: [expectation]. Can we agree on that, and how can I help?" Define success clearly and offer support.

Remember: The conversation isn't over when you deliver feedback. Follow up regularly, acknowledge progress, and adjust your approach if needed. Sustainable change requires ongoing support.



THE 60-SECOND PITCH



Sixty seconds isn't much time, but it's often all you get with senior leaders. The elevator pitch isn't about cramming in every detail—it's about sparking interest and earning a longer conversation. Master this structure and you'll be ready when opportunity knocks.

The best pitches follow a proven structure that mirrors how executives think: problem, solution, impact. Each element builds on the previous one, creating a compelling narrative arc that leads to action.



HOOK (10 SEC)

Start with a compelling fact, surprising statistic, or provocative question that grabs attention immediately. "We're losing \$500K/year to inefficient processes."



PROBLEM (15 SEC)

Define the challenge clearly. "Our system requires 15 manual steps that create bottlenecks, errors, and frustrated customers."



SOLUTION (20 SEC)

Present your recommendation concisely. "I'm proposing automation that reduces this to 3 steps using existing tools and a 6-week implementation."



IMPACT (15 SEC)

Quantify the expected result. "This saves \$500K annually and frees 20 hours/week for the team to focus on strategic work."

 **Practice Out Loud:** The pitch that sounds perfect in your head often runs long when spoken. Time yourself and trim ruthlessly. Every word must earn its place.



COMMUNICATION CHECKLIST

Before sending any important communication, run through this checklist. These six questions catch most common mistakes and significantly improve your message quality. Spending an extra two minutes on this review can save hours of confusion and back-and-forth later.

01

MAIN POINT FIRST?

Is your primary message clear in the first sentence? Executives read top-down and may not reach your third paragraph. Lead with what matters most.

02

REMOVED UNNECESSARY WORDS?

Edit ruthlessly. "In order to" becomes "to." "Due to the fact that" becomes "because." Every extra word dilutes your message. Aim for 30% fewer words in your second draft.

03

ASK IS SPECIFIC?

Can the reader take action immediately after reading? "Let me know what you think" is vague. "Please approve option B by Friday" is specific and actionable.

04

EASY TO SAY YES?

Have you removed barriers to agreement? Provide context, do the analysis, offer a recommendation. Make it easy for them to respond with a simple confirmation.

05

TONE IS CONFIDENT?

Cut hedging language like "I think," "maybe," or "just wondering." Be direct without being arrogant. "I recommend" is stronger than "I was thinking we might possibly."

06

PROOFREAD FOR TYPOS?

Read your message out loud or backward. Typos undermine credibility, especially with senior leaders. Tools like Grammarly help, but human review catches context errors.



CLARITY, BREVITY, IMPACT

1

CLARITY

Your reader should never have to guess what you mean or read something twice. Use simple words, short sentences, and logical structure. Remove jargon unless you're certain your audience knows it.

Test for clarity: Can someone unfamiliar with the context understand your main point? If not, simplify.

2

BREVITY

Respect your reader's time. Every sentence should serve a purpose. If it doesn't add value, cut it. The best communicators say more with less.

Challenge: After writing, cut 25% of your words. Your message will be stronger, not weaker.

3

IMPACT

Great communication drives action. End with a clear next step, decision point, or takeaway. Your reader should know exactly what to do after reading.

Ask yourself: What do I want to happen as a result of this communication?

30%

SHORTER

Effective messages use 30% fewer words than first drafts

7SEC

ATTENTION SPAN

You have 7 seconds to capture an executive's attention

3X

READ RATE

Clear communication is read 3x more often than dense text

Master these templates and you'll communicate with the precision and impact of the world's best executives. Copy them. Customize them. Make them your own. Then watch your influence grow as you consistently deliver clear, concise, and compelling messages that drive results.